

CHRISTIAN ENGAGEMENT OF THE WORLD — DYNAMIC DIFFERENTIATION

Get involved. And never lose sight of what is ultimate.

A Recipe for Christian involvement in the public sphere. First, be dynamically involved, engaging with the culture for the sake of the church and for the sake of the public good. Second, discern and differentiate between God's two kingdoms. Recognize the temporal role of the government in preserving peace and security, and recognize the eternal role of the church in bringing the good news of salvation to the world. Neither the church nor the state ought to usurp the other's role.

Give to Caesar what is Caesar's and give to God what is God's.

LUKE 20:25

In this dynamic differentiation, Jesus' words in Luke 20:25 guide us. The two important questions for good "public" engagement of issues and policies are:

- **What does God desire of Caesar?**
- **What does God want His people to do in support of Caesar?**

Paul answered both questions in Romans 13:

Let every person be subject to the governing authorities. For there is no authority except from God, and those that exist have been instituted by God. Therefore whoever resists the authorities resists what God has appointed, and those who resist will incur judgment. For rulers are not a terror to good conduct, but to bad. Would you have no fear of the one who is in authority? Then do what is good, and you will receive his approval, for he is God's servant for your good. But if you do wrong, be afraid, for he does not bear the sword in vain. For he is the servant of God, an avenger who carries out God's wrath on the wrongdoer. Therefore one must be in subjection, not only to avoid God's wrath but also for the sake of conscience. For because of this you also pay taxes, for the authorities are ministers of God, attending to this very thing. Pay to all what is owed to them: taxes to whom taxes are owed, revenue to whom revenue is owed, respect to whom respect is owed, honor to whom honor is owed.

ROMANS 13:1-7

God desires Caesar (the government) to be his servant for good, to punish wrongdoers, to encourage those who do well, and to bear the sword for the preservation of society. Christian citizens, likewise,

are called to give honor to this work of the government and to respect those in authority. Nevertheless, we also recognize that our leaders can't solve the biggest problem of life – sin. Power and government can control bad folks to a degree with the sword, but the only thing that can change the heart is the Gospel of Jesus Christ.

When it comes to public life, therefore, we Christians need to be “dynamically engaged,” encouraging the government in its God given, left-hand kingdom role to preserve justice, safety, and civility. We also need to recognize, however, God's more important right-hand kingdom work. In his left-hand kingdom, God blesses his people with temporal goods, curbing evil through law-enforcement, and providing for the blessings of society through marriage, vocation, and commerce. In his right hand kingdom, however, God brings to his people the eternal and ultimate gift of salvation through Christ. As two-kingdom citizens, Christians do all the temporal things of the left hand kingdom ultimately in service of the eternal things of the Gospel.

In Biblical times there were many different governing authorities. At the time of Jesus the Roman Empire dominated and Caesar ruled as king. In the United States, the Constitution makes the citizens sovereign, creating a government “of the people, by the people, for the people.” That remarkable turnaround has brought tremendous blessings of freedom to America, but with such freedom, it is even more important for Christians to be disciplined, religious citizens, and to use our freedom well. St. Paul's admonition in Romans 13 cuts both ways. We aren't just called to honor those elected officials, we too need to be honorable, and in America, we don't just submit to the laws of the land, we also have the responsibility to participate in creating those laws for the good of all.

To that end we encourage Christians to be dynamic. Get involved in the public sphere, advocate for the God-given role of government, model the virtues of a good citizen and thus have no fear of a good government. All the while, however, realize what is ultimate and fundamental to promote the spreading of the gospel to all the world. Dynamic Differentiation. Get involved (dynamic) but always be active in appreciating God's primary work – the salvation of sinners (differentiation).

This calls for Christians to be a unique kind of citizen no matter what country they are in, but in the United States, it gives us a wonderful way to exercise our free citizenship in Christian love and service toward others.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

Work through these with your group, then with a friend or your spouse — without the sheet.

- 1 To be dynamic means to be actively engaged. How is God dynamic in the left-hand kingdom?

- 2 To be dynamic means to be actively engaged. How is God dynamic in the right-hand kingdom?

- 3 The first line of the United States Constitution states that “We the people” are the ones that establish the laws. How does that impact our being involved in the enactment and enforcement of these laws?
